and had grown up in the same regiment. I had a successful tenure as the colonel of the regiment for six years till I retired in September 2007.

During this period, I focused on policy decisions for the good of the regiment and improvements of infrastructure and accommodation in the Regimental Centre at Belgaum and in regimental assets at other locations. Based on research and deliberations and importantly, with the consensus of the entire regiment, we reverted to the custom of wearing our green lanyard not around the neck but on the left shouldier, except the 5th Battalion, which proudly wore the royal blue lanyard on the right shoulder as before. Besides that, we introduced the black pouch belt to be worn on ceremonial occasions.

Five significant events occurred during my tenure as the colonel of the regiment. The first was the bicentenary celebrations of 5 (Royal) Maratha LI at Kota in December 2001, which was raised during the Raj period on 21 December 1800. As covered earlier, I had the privilege to command this very fine battalion from 1985–87 at Hyderabad.

The 5th Royals bicentenary was conducted in a grand manner from 11 to 14 October 2001. It was a gala reunion, with a ceremonial parade reviewed by me as the colonel of the regiment, the Maratha pageant, followed by a 'bara khana' (a combined dinner for all ranks), and the bicentenary dinner in the officers' mess. The Bicentenary Cup was unveiled that evening for which all officers had contributed. Made of sterling silver, it was a matching trophy to the Centenary Cup presented by all officers on 21 December 1900 (they were all British), and is proudly displayed in the ante-room of the mess. Former colonels of the regiment, Generals E. D'Souza, Bachhitar Singh, Vijay Oberoi, along with Generals K.S. Brar, D.B. Shekhatkar, S. Satpute and C.K. Karumbaya, were present at these functions.

On 30 January 2003, we had an impressive affiliation ceremony on board INS Mumbai, one of our navy's latest warships – a state-of-the-art guided missile destroyer, with the motto 'I am invincible.' I reviewed the joint Guard of Honour and told the gathering that the